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AUTNES Content Analysis of Campaign Facebook Pages 2017

Coding procedure & list of variables

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Introduction

The dataset "AUTNES Content Analysis of Facebook Pages 2017" was collected through a manual content analysis of the party Facebook postings in the 2017 Austrian election campaign. Data collection took place under the auspices of the Austrian National Election Study (AUTNES), a National Research Network funded by the Austrian Science Fund (FWF) (grant no. S10903-G11). Additional funding was provided by the Federal Ministry of Education, Science and Research (BMBWF) within the Austrian Cooperative Infrastructure for Electoral Research (ACIER).

AUTNES applies a common method of content analysis to different sources. This coding scheme is described in greater detail in the AUTNES documentation for the analysis of party press releases (doi: 10.11587/25P2WR). The document at hand builds upon this description and gives details only for adaptions of the coding scheme that aim at maximising the validity of the Facebook coding. Inquiries on further details regarding the data and coding can be directed at Laurenz Ennser-Jedenastik (laurenz.ennser@univie.ac.at) at the University of Vienna's Department of Government.

How to cite these data:

Data users are kindly asked to acknowledge the data *and* the accompanying release document. Please refer to the AUSSDA data catalogue (https://data.aussda.at/, doi: 10.11587/17OKDP) for a recommendation on how to cite these data and the documentation.

Conditions of use

Restrictions

The data are available under the terms listed at the AUSSDA Dataverse.

Confidentiality

AUTNES, the Principal Investigators and the funding institutions bear no responsibility for the use of the data, or for interpretations or inferences based on their use, neither do they accept liability for indirect, consequential or incidental damages or losses arising from use of the data.

Deposit Requirement

In order to facilitate exchanges within the scientific community and to provide funding agencies with essential information about the use of archival resources, users of the AUTNES data are requested to notify the AUTNES team of all forms of publications making use of AUTNES data (mail@autnes.at).

Description of the dataset and coding process

The dataset holds information of party Facebook postings during the six weeks of election campaign for the Austrian general election in 2017. We retrieved postings for all parties that had reasonable chances for passing the threshold for entering the parliament in 2017.

We used the Facebook API to collect the data. The API allows for extracting technical information such as the text of the posting, the count of user interactions and the URL of the post. The variables v03 through v09_8 contain this information. In a second step, the postings were coded manually by trained student coders under the close supervision of AUTNES team members. Each posting constitutes a unit of observation. The coders used screenshots collected a few hours after the postings were published, thus simulating the situation of users scrolling through their news feed. This allows us to code text and actors from visual data (e.g. pictures).

ID Variables

status_id

- *Description:* status ID given by Facebook
- *Type:* string

v01 id

- *Description:* ID variable
- *Type:* numeric

v02 coder id

- *Description:* coder ID
- *Type:* string

Variables referring to Facebook posting: web scraping

v03 URL

- *Description:* URL of Facebook posting
- *Type:* string

v04 type of Facebook page

- *Description:* This variable indicates whether the Facebook page is a party or candidate page.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
  - (1) party page
  - (2) candidate page

v05 timestamp posting

- *Description:* v05 contains the date and time when the Facebook post was posted (4 September 2017 – 14 October 2017).
- *Type:* time (DD-MMM-YYYY, hh:mm:ss)

v06 post_message

- *Description:* v06 contains the text of the Facebook posting.
- *Type:* string

v09 interaction: date

- *Description:* v09 indicates the date the interactions were collected. If possible, this date is 5 days after the posting was published. In some cases, this was not possible due to technical problems or because the posting was already deleted at this point.
- *Type:* date

v09_1 interaction likes

- *Description:* number of likes.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_2 interaction: comments

- *Description:* number of comments.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_3 interaction: shares

- *Description:* number of shares.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_4 interaction: loves

- *Description:* number of loves.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_5 interaction: wow

- *Description:* number of wows.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_6 interaction: haha

- *Description:* number of hahas.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_7 interaction: sad

- *Description:* number of sads.
- *Type:* numeric

v09_8 interaction: angry

- *Description:* number of angries.
- *Type:* numeric

Variables referring to Facebook posting: manual coding

v10 technical problems

- *Description:* This variable states whether the coder encountered technical problems (for example due to expired links).
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
  - (0) no technical problems
  - (1) technical problems

v10a only text coded

- *Description:* This variable states whether the coder coded this posting using only text because of technical problems (for example, the picture or video was not available anymore).
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
  - (0) posting coded using all information
  - (1) posting coded only referring to text

v12 continuous text

- *Description:* Does the posting contain continuous text?
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
  - (0) no text
  - (1) text

v13 picture

- *Description:* Does the posting contain a picture?
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
  - (0) no picture
  - (1) picture

v14 video

- *Description:* Does the posting contain a video?
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
  - (0) no video
  - (1) video

Variables referring to the author

v15a author: org

- *Description:* This variable indicates the organisation of the Facebook site's author.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations
    - (1100000) Social Democratic Party of Austria (SPÖ)
    - (1200000) Austrian People's Party (ÖVP)
    - (1300000) Freedom Party of Austria (FPÖ)
    - (1400000) Austrian Green Party (Greens)
    - (2400000) NEOS - The New Austria and Liberal Forum
    - (2700000) JETZT - Pilz List

v15b author: name

- *Description:* This variable indicates the name of the Facebook site's author. This variable is only relevant for Facebook pages of top candidates.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*: according to AUTNES list of individuals
    - (1) no individual actor
    - (10) Heinz-Christian Strache
    - (76) Ulrike Lunacek
    - (214) Peter Pilz
    - (319) Sebastian Kurz
    - (1291) Christian Kern
    - (1606) Matthias Strolz

v16 author: appearance

- *Description:* This variable indicates whether the author is mentioned in the posting.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (0) not mentioned
    - (1) text
    - (2) picture
    - (3) text + picture

Variables referring to issues

One policy issue and one campaign issue were coded per unit. If more than one issue was mentioned, the coders chose the dominant issue. Only written information was coded, images of issues without text were coded as “77777 - image of issue, no text”.

v20 campaign issue

- *Description:* Coded campaign issue.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*: according to AUTNES list of issues
    - (77777) image of issue, no text
    - (99999) not classifiable

v21 predicate

- *Description:* Author’s position towards the coded policy issue (v22).
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (-1) rejection/criticism
    - (0) neutral
    - (1) support

v22 policy issue

- *Description:* Coded policy issue.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*: according to AUTNES list of issues
    - (77777) image of issue, no text
    - (99999) not classifiable

v23 reference to EU

- *Description:* Does the posting refer to regulation of the issue coded in v22 on the European level?
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values:*
    - (0) no reference to EU
    - (1) reference to EU

Variables referring to object actors

Up to ten object actors were coded per posting. The digit after the underscore indicates to which object actor the variable refers to. For example, v26_1 gives the name of the first object actor whereas v26_10 holds the name of the tenth object actor. Organisations, for example parties or companies, were coded when written information was given. Individuals were always coded when they were mentioned as text. Moreover, a list of prominent political actors (including for example top candidates, high ranking party officials, members of the national government, head of the state) was defined. These prominent actors were coded even if they were only present in pictures but not mentioned in written form. Variable v28 contains information about the appearance of an object actor in written form or in a picture. Individuals in pictures that were not classified as prominent were not coded as object actor but in the variable related to pictures of individuals (v36).

v25_1-v25_10 object actor 1-10: presence

- *Description:* Binary variable indicating whether an object actor was coded.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (0) no object
    - (1) object coded

v26_1-v26_10 object actor 1-10: name

- *Description:* This variable contains the names of individuals that were coded as object actors.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*: according to AUTNES list of individuals
    - (1) no individual actor
    - (99999) private individual

v27_1-v27_10 object actor 1-10: organisation

- *Description:* This variable contains the object actor's organisation.
- *Type*: numeric
- *Values:* according to AUTNES list of organisations
    - (9900000) no actor (organisation)

v28_1-v28_10 object actor 1-10: appearance

- *Description:* This variable indicates whether the object actor is mentioned in written form, as picture or both.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (1) text
    - (2) picture
    - (3) text + picture

v29_1-v29_10 object actor 1-10: predicate

- *Description:* This variable indicates the relation between the author of the posting and the object actor. If no written information is given, this variable is coded as "88 – picture".

- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (-1) rejection/criticism
    - (0) neutral
    - (1) support
    - (88) picture
    - (99) not classifiable

v31_1-v31_10 object actor 1-10: reference to campaign issue

- *Description:* This variable indicates whether the object actor makes a reference to the coded campaign issue (v20). "1 – text reference" is coded if the object actor makes a reference towards the coded issue in written form. "2 – image reference" is coded if there is no explicit relation between the object actor and the coded issue in written form, but a picture of the object actor indicates a connection.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (0) no reference
    - (1) text reference
    - (2) image reference

v32_1-v32_10 object actor 1-10: reference to policy issue

- *Description:* This variable indicates whether the object actor makes a reference to the coded policy issue (v22). "1 – text reference" is coded if the object actor makes a reference towards the coded issue in written form. "2 – image reference" is coded if there is no explicit relation between the object actor and the coded issue in written form, but a picture of the object actor indicates a connection.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
    - (0) no reference
    - (1) text reference
    - (2) image reference

v35 additional object actors

- *Description:* This variable gives the number of object actors that were not coded due to the instruction to only code the first ten object actors per posting.
- *Type*: numeric

Variables referring to pictures

v36 picture of individuals

- *Description:* This variable indicates whether the posting contains pictures of non-coded individuals.
- *Type:* numeric
- *Values*:
  - (0) no pictures of individuals
  - (1) pictures of individuals